Fazl too was killed in this bleak and desolate setting in August 1602. Bir Singh had Abu'l Fazl's head cut off and sent it to Salim who, it was said, was delighted and had it 'thrown into an unworthy place'.

Bir Singh Deo of Orchha was one of the many rajas and noblemen who had clustered to Salim's rebellious court at Allahabad. In Salim, Bir Singh found a sympathetic repository for his stories of unfulfilled ambitions, and the prince had promised to help Bir Singh once he had become Padshah. But the price he demanded was blood. Salim understood that if Abu'l Fazl were to reach Agra, then any chance of reconciliation with his formidable father would evaporate. In his memoirs, Salim would write candidly about this less than illustrious episode of his life. 'Shaykh Abu'l Fazl…who was outstanding in his learning and wisdom,' he wrote, 'was suspicious of me (and) was always making snide remarks. At that time, because of the corruption of mischief-makers, my exalted father's mind was quite turned against me, and it was certain that if (Abu'l Fazl) succeeded in reaching him he would create more discord…' It was necessary, therefore, that Abu'l Fazl be prevented from meeting Akbar and so, wrote Salim, 'I sent (Bir Singh) a message that he should waylay the miscreant and dispatch him to non-existence, in return for which he could expect great rewards from me.'

Salim's forthright style notwithstanding, Bir Singh's murder of Abu'l Fazl seems to have caused some dismay and disquiet amongst the Bundelkhandis themselves, for Keshavdas, Bir Singh Deo's court poet, struggled to justify this action in his *Virsimhdevcarit* in praise of his patron. Indeed, when he came to write about this fateful and bloody pact, Keshavdas proposed that Bir Singh tried to dissuade Salim from his dreadful decision:

> Considering political expediency
> Overcoming fear, and maintaining clarity of thought
> Bir Singh folded his hands and entreated,
> 'You are the master and he (Abu'l Fazl) the slave, Excellency.
> Is it therefore fitting to display such wrath?
> A lord shows leniency towards his servants.
> It is a mark of lordship to protect.
> Please don't harbour a grudge against him.
> Give up your anger, and make peace.